provided the ideal breeding grounds for insurgency and terrorism, and Mizoram had an unduly large share of the ravages that such scourges bring about. Suffice it to say that Aizawl has the dubious distinction of being the only place in our country that has been bombed by its own air force.

The Hmars constituted the most prominent group of Mizos involved in insurgency operations. Their numbers were relatively larger than the rest of the tribes and since they spoke a very different dialect from the others, they could form a very cohesive group. The army and the police, therefore, had quite a job on their hands in dealing with the Mizo hostilities in the area. However, through sustained and coordinated efforts, they could ultimately manage to contain the situation and bring the Hmar Revolutionary Council (HRC) from a position where it could dictate terms to one where it sought surrender and rehabilitation. The only alternative for the HRC members would probably have been decimation. Unfortunate as most such conflicts were, the Mizos had lost a lot by then.

Mizoram signed the peace accord after several years of insurgency. By the time Kiran was posted there as deputy inspector general (range) [DIG(R)], the overall situation had already limped back to near-normal. Since there was no electricity in most of the areas and because of years of curfew conditions that had prevailed, the Mizos were quite used to waking up with the sun and going indoors at sunset. Gradually, however, the situation started to change and the evenings, especially during summer, saw groups of young boys and girls sitting outside their houses and singing to the accompaniment of guitars, or leisurely strolling down the streets. The Mizo community was quite liberal in its social norms and there was free intermingling of boys and girls without any parental frowning upon their activities. The youngsters chose their own marriage partners, and divorce was not uncommon.

As already mentioned, Mizoram has a very porous eastern border and drug abuse was rampant among its youth. This factor, combined with the general air of permissiveness amongst its youth, had made Mizoram one of the states with the highest incidence of AIDS. Mizos did not grow enough quantities of rice and the Centre had to provide large subsidies for this cereal. However, a lot of this rice was diverted to brewing the local drink called Zu in the Mizo language. The incidence of alcoholism, too, was consequently very high.

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As with any newly formed state, the Mizos were very suspicious of non-Mizos. They called outsiders ‘Vais’, and their distrust bordered on hostility. Given such conditions in Mizoram, the non-Mizos faced a very difficult time there. The majority of criminal offences were directed towards the outsiders. They were repeatedly looted and were afraid to make formal complaints lest they be further harassed. Most of the lower ranks of the police were made up of Mizos and, given the close community links, they were somehow or the other related to most of the local families. The Vais, therefore, stood very little chance of seeing justice done and preferred to bear their fate stoically. A number of them were married to local girls but have not been accepted by the Mizo community. They naturally let things be in the hope that they would be spared in the future for being ‘good boys’. Yet they continued to stay on because they would rather not face the trauma of relocating their homes.

Without getting into the political dimensions of the Chakma (refugees from Bangladesh) problem, one can quite realize the cause of the enormous aggression shown towards them by the Mizos, with murder, arson and pillage being the norms of the day.

Mizoram has but one law and order range. The tasks of its DIG (R), therefore, include looking after the law and order situation, crime prevention, protection of the people and public property, management of traffic and checking the menace of drug abuse by destroying the sources (of the drugs)